They took four days, and they were nothing like exams at Eton. There was *some* bookwork, *some* written stuff, but mostly they were tests for psychological toughness and leadership skills.

Turned out…I had both. I passed with flying colors.

I was delighted. My trouble concentrating, my trauma over my mother, none of that came into play. None of that counted against me with the British Army. On the contrary, I discovered, those things made me all the more ideal. The Army was *looking* for lads like me.

What's that you say, young man? Parents divorced? Mum's dead? Unresolved grief or psychological trauma? Step this way!

Along with news that I'd passed I received a report date, several months away. Which meant I'd have time to gather my thoughts, tie up loose ends. Even better, time to spend with Chels…if she'd have me?

She would. She invited me to come back to Cape Town, meet her parents.

I did. And liked them instantly. They were impossible not to like. They enjoyed funny stories, gin and tonics, good food, stalking. Her father was bear-sized, broad-shouldered, cuddly, but also a definite alpha. Her mother was petite, an amazing listener, and a frequent bestower of epic hugs. I didn't know what the future held, I didn't want to put any carts before any horses, but I thought: If you designed in-laws from the ground up, you couldn't do much better than these guys.

48.

THERE MUST HAVE BEEN something in the air. Just as I was embarking on my new romance, Pa announced that he'd decided to marry. He'd asked Granny's permission, and she'd granted it. Reluctantly, it was reported.

Despite Willy and me urging him not to, Pa was going ahead. We pumped his hand, wished him well. No hard feelings. We recognized that he was finally going to be with the woman he loved, the woman he'd always loved, the woman Fate might've intended for him in the first place. Whatever bitterness or sorrow we felt over the closing of another loop in Mummy's story, we understood that it was beside the point.